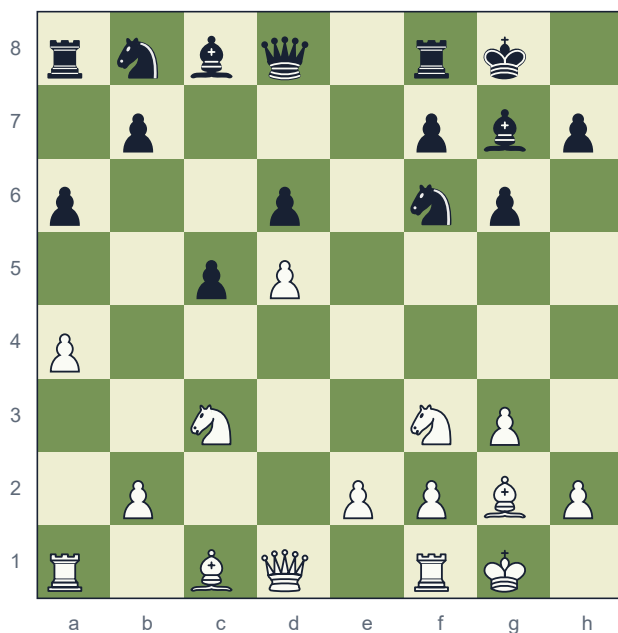


Modern Benoni: space and the fianchetto

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Keep a pawn on d5 and use a kingside fianchetto to build a coherent setup. The center gives you space; Black's queenside majority and active pieces create counterplay.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

After ...exd5 and cxd5, White has a central space advantage while Black has a queenside pawn majority. The d6 pawn is a potential target, but ...b5 can be a powerful freeing move.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black seeks ...b5, pressure down the e-file, and piece activity against e4 or d5. A rook on e8 and bishop on g7 can cooperate tactically.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Restrain ...b5 when useful, but do not make every move a defensive pawn move.
2. The d6 pawn may be weak, yet Black's active pieces can make capturing it impossible.
3. The key white breakthrough is often e4-e5, prepared by development and central support.

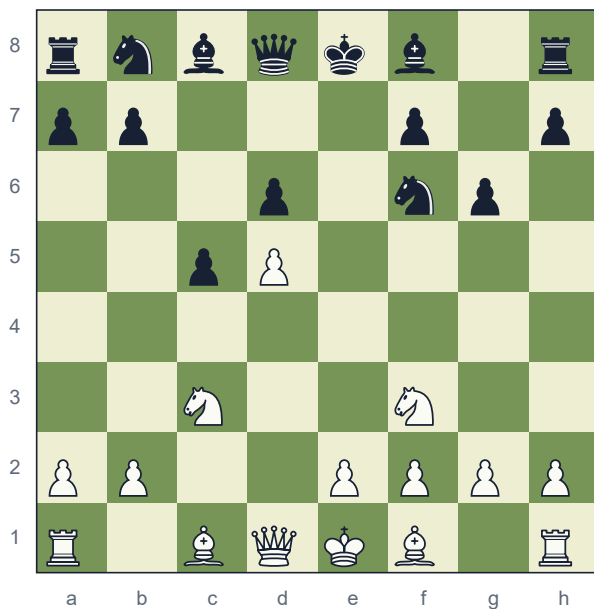
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 The fianchetto main setup

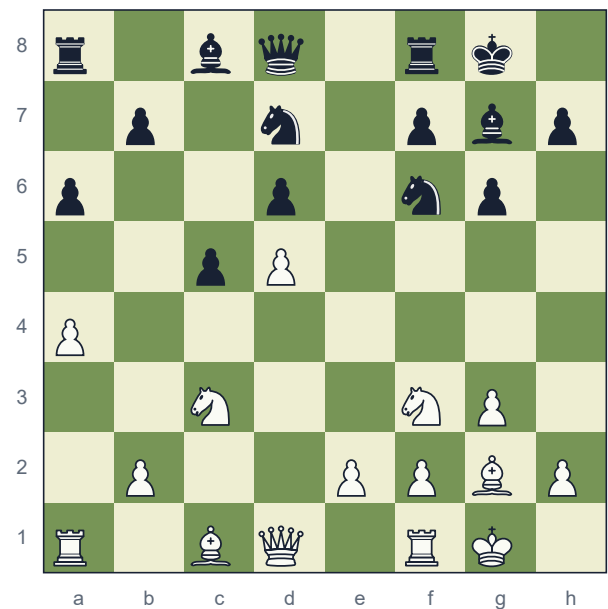
STUDY LINE 16-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. g3 Bg7 8. Bg2 O-O 9. O-O a6 10. a4 Nbd7

Selected anchor ends with 10. a4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 makes ...b5 harder to achieve. The g2 bishop supports the center while the king reaches safety.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the c1 bishop and prepare e4. Use rooks on central files and watch for an e5 breakthrough when it opens lines favorably.

WATCH FOR

After a4, the b4 square may become available to a black knight. Preventing one break can concede a square.

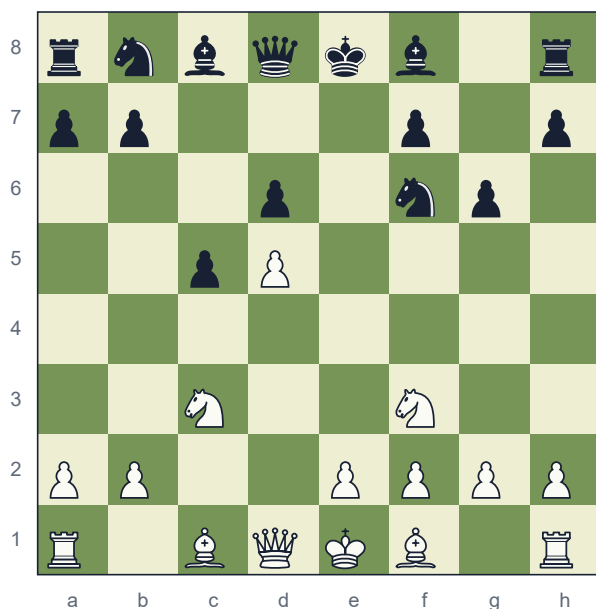
REMEMBER Keep d5, complete development, prepare e4-e5.

02 Black delays castling

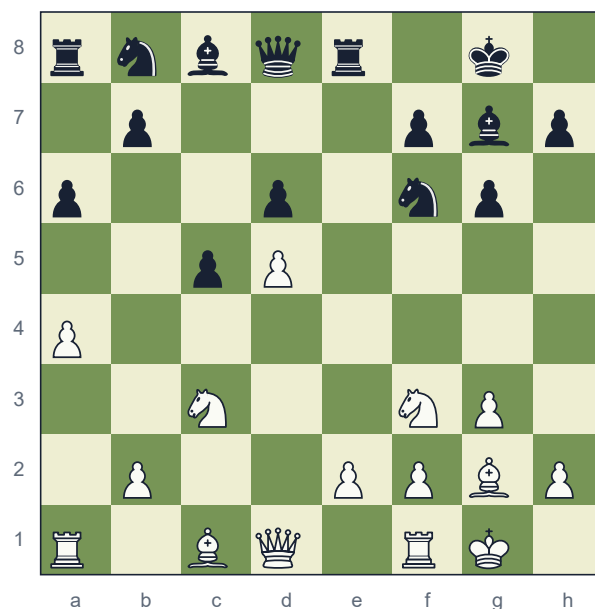
STUDY LINE 16-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. g3 Bg7 8. Bg2 a6 9. O-O O-O 10. a4 Re8

Selected anchor ends with 9. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White need not delay king safety just because Black does. The center and ...b5 remain the strategic questions.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

a4 may restrain ...b5; e4 builds the full center if supported. Compare these moves rather than choosing by habit.

WATCH FOR

A premature e5 may release Black's cramped position with favorable exchanges.

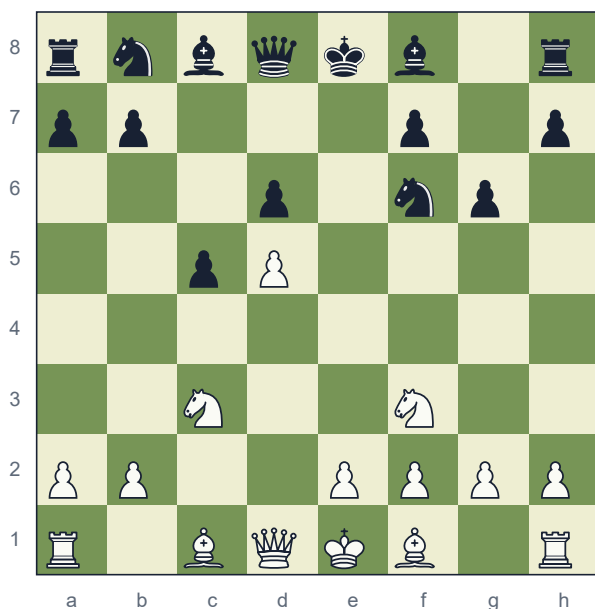
REMEMBER Prepare the central break rather than forcing it.

03 The ...e6 move order after 3.Nf3

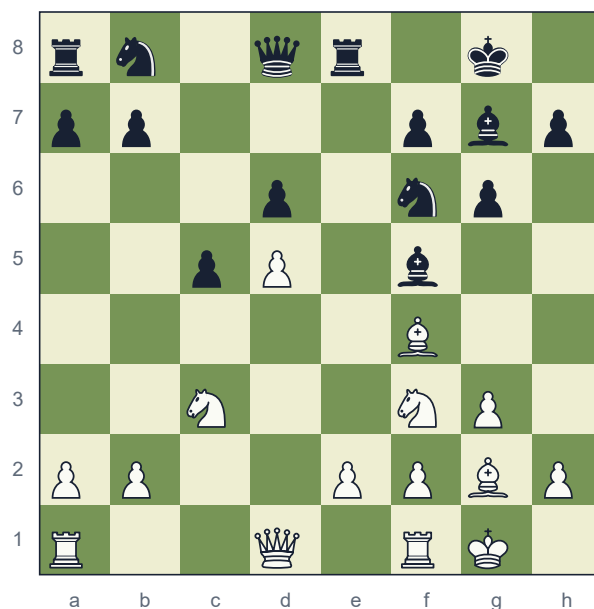
STUDY LINE 16-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. d5 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nc3 g6 7. g3 Bg7 8. Bf4 O-O 9. Bg2 Re8 10. O-O Bf5

Selected anchor ends with 7. g3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This transposes to the same fianchetto Benoni with the f3 knight developed earlier. Your repertoire remains coherent across both move orders.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bg2, O-O and restraint of ...b5 are familiar goals. Check whether Black inserted a useful move before calling the position identical.

WATCH FOR

If Black plays ...b5 instead of ...exd5, consult the Blumenfeld section; do not recapture a pawn that has not been exchanged.

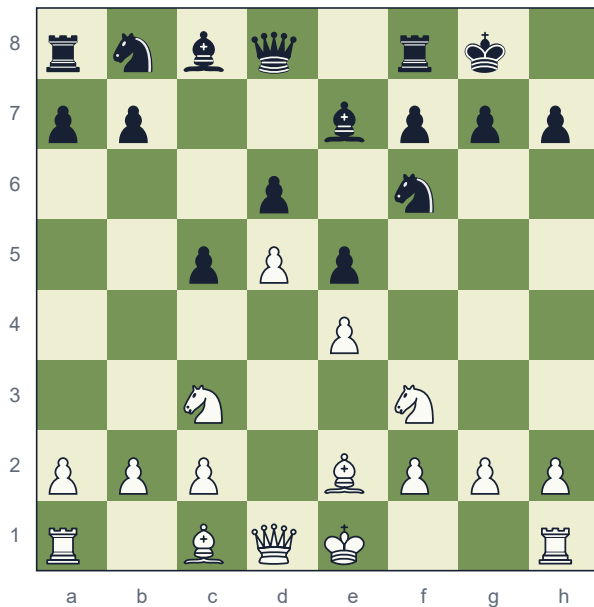
REMEMBER Recognize the transposition and the alternative gambit.

04 Old Benoni: the locked center

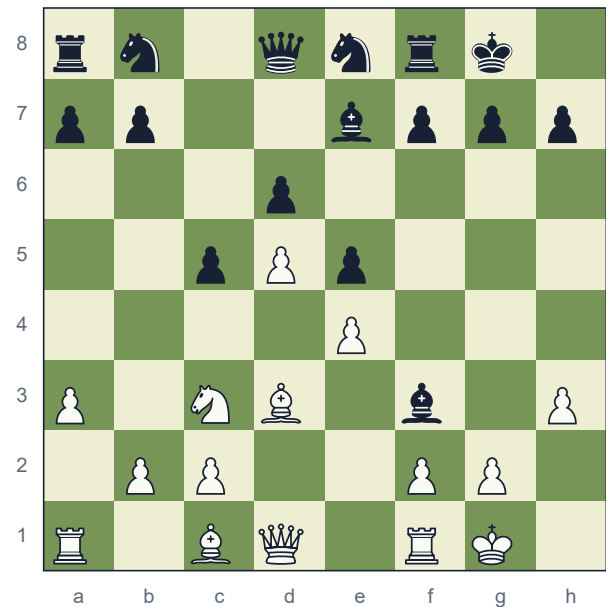
STUDY LINE 16-04

1. d4 c5 2. d5 e5 3. e4 d6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Nc3 Be7 6. Be2 O-O 7. O-O Ne8 8. Bd3 Bd7 9. a3 Bg4 10. h3 Bxf3

Selected anchor ends with 7. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Here White deferred c4 and took e4. The center is locked, so the right wing for play depends on piece placement and possible pawn breaks.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

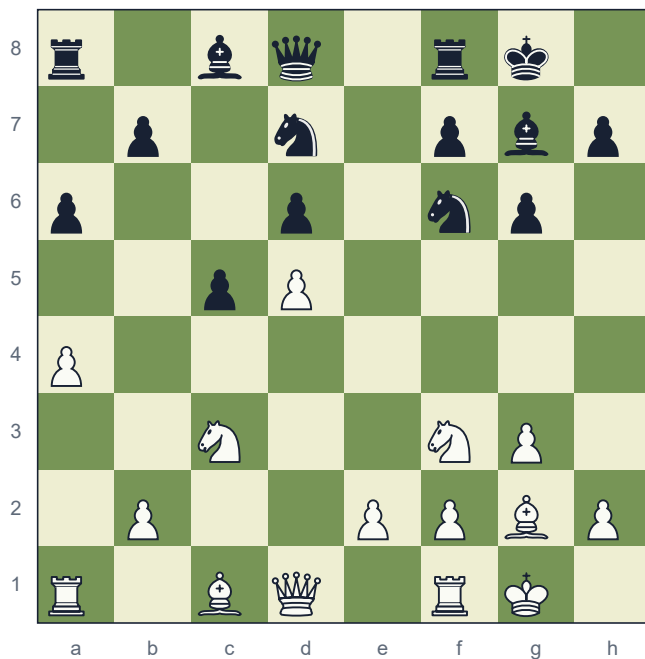
Prepare a queenside expansion or central undermining move. c4 is optional later; it should improve control rather than merely imitate another opening.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume a locked center makes kingside pawn advances safe forever. A break can open files suddenly.

REMEMBER This is a different pawn skeleton from the Modern Benoni.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

After ...exd5 and cxd5, White has a central space advantage while Black has a queenside pawn majority. The d6 pawn is a potential target, but ...b5 can be a powerful freeing move.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black seeks ...b5, pressure down the e-file, and piece activity against e4 or d5. A rook on e8 and bishop on g7 can cooperate tactically.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the c1 bishop and prepare e4. Use rooks on central files and watch for an e5 breakthrough when it opens lines favorably.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.